

Host (Faria Akhtar): Science fiction movies is one of the most favorite genre of this generation. I mean, who doesn't love to watch a science fiction movie? But how long would we watch a science fiction movie of other countries? Don't we deserve to watch Bangladeshi science fiction movies, too? Science fiction movies in Bangladesh film industry—well, that's a discussion. Hello and welcome to our podcast show, Cinecast. Our today's topic is, "Why doesn't Bangladesh film industry make science fiction movies?" I am your host, Faria Akhtar. Our today's guest is Mahbubul Ontor, former CEO of Cinemascope. Hello.

Guest (Mahbubul Ontor): Hello.

Host: Can you introduce yourself to our audience?

Guest: So, as you just said, I was the former CEO of Cinemascope. Other than that, I have worked in the TV industry for several years right now. And I am trying to explore the world of cinema in Bangladesh right now with different film genres, actually. So, yeah, it's been almost 14–15 years now that I am trying to study filmmaking. Yeah, that's me.

Host: About science fiction movies, why aren't there any science fiction movie in Bangladesh film industry?

Guest: So, to be honest, to make a science fiction film, we need a huge budget, right? If we talk about films like *Interstellar* or others like *Gravity*, those were a top-of-their-budget line, right? And if we talk about the other things—the imagination part—I think Bangladesh is, Bangladeshi filmmakers, not Bangladesh, Bangladeshi filmmakers are actually lacking in both the terms. We don't have any budget, we can't make any film, and we don't have the imagination to bring out something new or explore anything new.

Host: A big budget can be a logical discussion, but there are plenty of science fiction movies in Hollywood which were successful at the box office despite of having low budget. Movies like *Coherence*, *Donnie Darko*, *The Butterfly Effect* can be a good example. You would be surprised to know *Coherence* had a budget of only \$50,000. So, do you really think budget is an obstacle for us?

Guest: That's the thing, right? As I said, the second biggest thing that is lacking in our filmmakers right now, or the film industry right now, that is the imagination—the thinking of something new, bringing something new, creating something new. Of course, you talk about *Coherence*, but if you see the story, they didn't need anything to show about a great, what I can say, science fiction. They just showed a simple story based on science fiction, right? So, in that sense, they had the imagination. They had that imagination to show. So, that's what we need right now.

Host: Ananta Jalil made *Din: The Day* with a budget of 100 crore taka. Can he be the savior of our industry in terms of making a big-budget science fiction movies?

Guest: So, first of all, Ananta Jalil's film was not a 100 crore film. It had some controversies, I don't want to go there and get beaten up. So, the thing is, Ananta Jalil is not a good actor. But if I talk about his passion towards film and his passion towards making a film with big budget, I would say he could be a very good key or a very good producer to the industry. If he gives money to filmmakers like Nuhash Humayun or other directors who are doing actually great, or they have the creativity to think, I think this combination of creative thinking and a good producer will make the industry a bang.

Host: Do you really think we lack science fiction stories? Because we have enough materials in our book industry. I mean, there are many well-written science fiction books in our country. So, do we actually lack of stories, or visualizing the story into a movie is the main problem for us?

Guest: If we go through our literature, right, we will see we have tons of science fiction books. But when we talk about the film industry, we are not adapting anything from that part. So, I would say the filmmakers now, they don't actually read stories. They just have a normal formula, and they want to make film based on that formula. So, we actually don't lack on stories, we just can't visualize it.

Host: Well, that makes sense. So to the viewers, we are getting a break now. Don't worry, we will be right back.

(Sponsorship Ad Break)

Host: Hello and welcome to the show again. I am your host, Faria Akhtar, and we have Mahbubul Ontor as our guest. So, shall we get back to the topic?

Guest: Are you asking for permission?

Host: Maybe.

Guest: Then it's a green light for me!

Host: So, *MR-9: Do or Die* movie released this week internationally, which had a budget of around 83 crore taka. So, do you think making a science fiction movie internationally could lighten the tension of big budget to spend?

Guest: If I talk about the collaboration part, right, that you know *MR-9* collaborated with US actors. So, I think that was a great move by the directors. But yeah, this might be a good option to explore the world with other film industries.

Host: ULAB Film Club, Media Club, or apprenticeship programs like CinemaScope can do more screening of science fiction movies in the campus. Do you think it would encourage youth filmmakers of ULAB, or is there something else clubs and apprenticeship programs can do?

Guest: See, watching film and getting inspiration or inspired is something very rare, okay? If I force any student to sit with me or the club or apprenticeship program you just mentioned, and talk—see a film for three hour, two hour 30 minute, it's not gonna help. He's gonna feel or she's gonna feel bored off, they will be bored out of it. But at the end of the day, if they have the passion and the club or apprenticeship program is trying to influence them, they should actually go through some tactics.

Host: I guess that is for today. It was an epic conversation with Mahbubul Ontor about making science fiction movies in our industry. Special thanks to our guest Mahbubul Ontor for being here, spending some time with us. Thanks to Tariquzzaman Shikdar for all the table works, thanks to Uchhas Ahmed Bappi for the technical support, and thanks to myself for being the best host in this room right now.

Guest: Ah, you are the best. Thank you so much for the invitation.

Host: Well, that is for today's episode. We would return to our second episode if we ever retake this course. Till then, goodbye. See you soon.